

POU11011: Introduction to Political Science

Lecture 2 (Teaching Week 2): Power — who actually decides?

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Power

Who actually decides?

Today

- A problem: power is everywhere in political talk, almost impossible to see
- Three progressively harder places to go looking for it
- The open question: how would you ever know these are real?

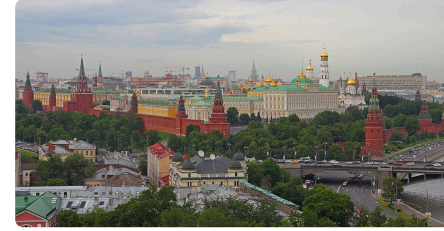
More on how this module works

- Two 50-minute lectures per week: Tuesdays 11am (B101), Fridays 1pm (Goldsmith)
- Four fortnightly tutorials across the term, led by TAs
- Readings: Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, 6th edition (2025)

SYLLABUS UPDATED - check it out

- You should have a tutorial assigned on your timetable – week of 5 Oct **OR** 12 Oct
- If you still don't **ON MONDAY**, contact Gabriela at polsci@tcd.ie
- You'll discuss recent topics with your classmates and the TA
- Attendance at all four tutorials is mandatory
- Submit a short set of discussion points to Blackboard by 5pm *the day before your tutorial*

Who am I?



- From Minneapolis, Minnesota
- Lived in New York, Abu Dhabi, and Moscow before Dublin
- My own research: Russian politics, authoritarian politics, *comparative politics*

Research topics:

- When and why Russian mayors get arrested
- Why some autocracies are more corrupt than others?
- How ordinary people decide whether to protest a repressive regime
- On what basis do political parties compete for votes...when the election is rigged?

Power!!

Power is exercised all the time, in small and large ways

Sometimes we can **observe** power being used, other times we can't

For political science, this is often a problem of **measurement**

The dog that didn't bark

1. A minister changes her mind about a bill after a phone call nobody else hears
2. A newspaper never runs the story it was pitched
3. You want what everyone around you already wants, and it never occurs to you to ask why

In none of these did anything visibly happen. No vote, no argument, no press conference.

So: how would you ever *observe* someone exercising power, when the whole point is that nothing observable happens?

Who has power over this room, right now?

- **Me.** I set today's agenda: what we discuss, what we skip, how long we spend on it
- **The timetabling office.** Decided you'd be here, this room, this hour, for 50 minutes
- **????** Whoever wrote the module regulations or created the module
- **The government?**

They're all real

None of them are the full story, though



Dahl's definition of power

Power: *A has power over B to the extent that A can get B to do something B would not otherwise do.*

Robert Dahl, 1957: deliberately minimal. Notice what it requires: **someone visibly not getting their way.**

Good enough for a lot of politics. Not good enough for everything on the previous slide, though!

We can say that power has **three “faces”**



The three faces of power

First Face of Power: the open fight



This is: who wins when two sides visibly disagree and one of them gets what it wanted

A minister wants a bill passed. Backbenchers object. It passes anyway.

That's power in its easy-to-see form.

This is Dahl's world: power as winning observable fights. Robert Dahl did exactly this: traced who won on housing, education, and urban renewal decisions in New Haven, Connecticut (*Who Governs?*, 1961).



Second Face of Power: the dog that didn't bark

Look for: which issues never even make it to a vote

Bachrach and Baratz: power isn't just winning decisions, it's controlling **which decisions get made at all**. They called the ones that never surface *non-decisions*.

Harder to observe than Face 1. You can't point to a vote that didn't happen. You have to notice an absence!

What won't any Irish party touch?

An issue that stays off the table because no mainstream party will ever put it up for a vote



One possibility: “culling the national herd”

- Agriculture produces 38% of Ireland’s greenhouse gas emissions (EPA, 2024)
- 2023: the Department of Agriculture models paying dairy farmers to leave, about 200,000 fewer cows over three years
- April 2024: the minister says the scheme is “off the table”

Face 2 in action: the obvious lever on the biggest source of emissions was modelled, then dropped. It never became a bill

Third Face of Power: wanting what suits them

Look for: cases where B never even *wants* to fight, because A shaped what B wants in the first place



“Is it not the supreme exercise of power to get another or others to have the desires you want them to have — that is, to secure their compliance by controlling their thoughts and desires?”

— Steven Lukes, Power: A Radical View (1974)

This is the one nobody has an easy method for. No vote to watch, no absence to notice, only a preference that looks, from the inside, completely freely chosen.



How would you ever know?

Face 3 claims someone's preferences were shaped by power. What evidence would ever let you say that, rather than just “that's what they happen to want”?

This is not a rhetorical question! It's a real *methodological* problem, still heavily contested among political scientists.

One serious attempt: Gaventa's valley

John Gaventa, *Power and Powerlessness* (1980): an Appalachian coal-mining valley, one company dominant for generations

Decades of Face 1 and Face 2 power drove a quiet “*that’s just how it is*” into how people saw their own situation.

Even here, we’re not observing Face 3 directly



How did Gaventa make the case?

The miners were badly exploited, and mostly they didn't organise, didn't vote against the company, and didn't talk about alternatives

- Not because they were satisfied
- Not because anyone forced them into silence on any given day

His evidence: decades of documented Face 1 wins and Face 2 non-decisions, plus the resistance that never appeared

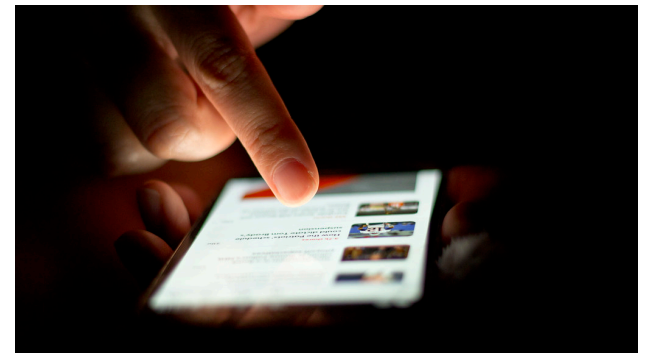
He doesn't prove Face 3 directly. He **reconstructs** it

“Learned helplessness”?

A more timely example

Advertising has always tried to do this. The newer version: algorithmic feeds that learn what keeps you scrolling and show you more of exactly that.

The Face 3 question again: if a feed shapes what you want and you experience that as just your own taste, is that power?



Could you run anything without exercising power?

A hospital, a household, a country, with *no one* having power over anyone. Could you?

Probably not: someone has to make things happen collectively

So the real questions are who has it, how they got it, and whether they're answerable

(Anarchists think you could. More on them in Lecture 6!)

Coercion vs authority

A Garda directing traffic and an armed robber both get *compliance*. But only one of them is exercising **authority**.

- **Coercion:** you comply because you'll be hurt if you don't
- **Authority:** you comply because you accept the other side's *right* to be obeyed

Legitimacy is what makes power cheap

Power is often costly to wield, we need shortcuts to make it cheaper – more on this next week

These faces of power are *everywhere* in politics

1. Winning the open fight
2. Keeping issues off the agenda
3. Shaping what people want in the first place

Summing up

- Power💪 is exercised all the time, often where nobody can see it
- Three faces: winning the open fight, keeping issues off the agenda, shaping what people want
- The harder the “face”, the harder the evidence: for political science, a problem of **measurement**

Next up

Lecture 3 on Tuesday. The state: where does this thing come from?

Every face of power we discussed today assumed something: a state, with rules, courts, and a monopoly on legitimate force

Think about it before next time: why does the state get to boss everyone around and what happens where nobody holds that monopoly?

See you Tuesday

See you Tuesday

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Slides and readings: noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou11011-mt2026

Reading for next time is on the module page and Blackboard.